

Delaware County Budget Hearing Afternoon Session - September 10th, 2026

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1Y6hyJ3OWTY
Publication Date	2026-09-10T20:20:46Z
Target Category	delaware_county

Notice: This report is provided by the [Muncie Policy Memo](#) as a public service. This summary is generated automatically using artificial intelligence from public video transcripts, both of which are prone to error. The report is intended to provide an overview of meeting business and an aid to accessing detailed information from the video recording. When accuracy is critical, please refer to the official video recording or approved minutes.

Municipal Meeting Report: Budget Work Session

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The County Council reconvened for an afternoon budget work session focused on reviewing department budgets, specifically covering the probation department, the courts, the sheriff's office, the auditor's office, and local income tax (LIT) funds.
- **Attendance:**
 - *Members Present:* Council President (presiding), Council Member Piper, Council Member Can, Council Member Bookout, Council Member Mo, and other council members.
 - *Key Officials & Presenters:* Jeff Hanser (Chief Probation Officer), the County Sheriff, Nancy (Sheriff's Office), Ed (Auditor), Jean Smoot (County Recorder), Alexis (Delaware County EMS), Commissioner Brandt, Elizabeth Wilcox, and Whitney.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** None recorded in this segment.
- **Approval of Minutes:** None recorded.

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:09:42 Probation Department Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jeff Hanser, Chief Probation Officer.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Mr. Hanser presented a 2026/2027 budget brief and spreadsheets detailing base salary rates, longevity, and insurance coverage for adult and juvenile probation officers. Approximately 25% of probation employees do not carry county insurance. Adult line officer caseloads range from 110 to 140; juvenile officer caseloads range from 25 to 30 due to higher statutory rehabilitation and multi-agency coordination requirements. The department collected \$250,000 in user fees and \$123,000 in grants in 2025. Council members discussed the mechanics of state-mandated salary schedules based on years of service versus local cost-of-living adjustments (COLA), noting that state-mandated steps must be honored while exploring funding split options between county general and user fee accounts.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus to level probation officer base salaries back to state-mandated minimums for review; no formal final vote taken during the work session.
- **00:45:57 Sheriff's Department & Jail Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** The County Sheriff and Nancy (Sheriff's Office).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The Sheriff presented pension data, noting an unfunded pension liability of nearly \$6.8 million as of January 1, 2026, with the fund currently at 78.6% funded. Through August, the pension's year-to-date return was 7.37% (exceeding the 6.5% actuarial requirement). Inmate housing billed \$1.1 million through August, expecting near \$1.7 million by year-end. Nancy detailed givebacks across various insurance and benefit lines in Fund 129 (\$68,300 total) and the jail budget (\$39,900 total), plus a \$4,500 reduction in the food contract based on contract terms. Council discussed funding the sheriff's pension at the recommended county contribution rate (\$1,524,080).
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Tentative agreement to maintain the sheriff's pension contribution at the recommended level and incorporate proposed departmental givebacks.
- **01:09:46 Auditor's Office & County IT/Software Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Ed (Auditor) and Elizabeth Wilcox.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The Auditor reviewed software and contractual service reductions, proposing to reduce unit computing from \$125k to \$85k (\$40k reduction) and eliminate \$21k in software costs now covered under Microsoft 365. Discussion ensued regarding OpenGov software modules, time clocks, and

enterprise resource planning. Department heads and officials (including representatives from EMS and highway departments) debated the utility, implementation hurdles, and software integration challenges of adopting OpenGov modules versus existing workflows. The council also addressed a \$25,500 line item for Policy Analytics, ultimately deciding to remove it temporarily.

- **Item-Specific Public Input:**
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reductions to contractual and software lines accepted tentatively; overall auditor and LIT budgets left for final compilation.
- **02:18:24 Public Defender Office Budget & Staffing**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Shelley Harvey (Public Defender's Office).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Shelley Harvey announced a \$40,000 giveback from the public defender's health insurance line (Dept 139). Council members discussed prosecutor-to-public defender salary pay parity surveys, statutory requirements, and average deputy prosecutor salaries (\$107,267 vs. base rates).
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Information noted; public defender office to recalculate figures for the next meeting.
- **02:31:52 County Recorder & Commissioner Updates**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jean Smoot (County Recorder) and Commissioner Brandt.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Jean Smoot discussed health insurance options for elected officials and deputies opting down to dental/vision coverage. Commissioner Brandt addressed historical line-item naming conventions (such as developmental disability vs. mental health adjustment lines 312 and 313), the community mental health provider (Meridian) funding constraints under state law (regarding executive compensation exceeding \$400k), and a list of commissioner contractual service vendors.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Information reviewed; staff directed to verify accounting nomenclature and line adjustments.

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **02:04:58 Alexis (Delaware County EMS):** Addressed the council regarding software systems and integration, supporting inter-system communication but noting concerns with OpenGov implementation and advocating for broader research into alternative software solutions.
 - **02:31:54 Jean Smoot (County Recorder):** Spoke regarding health insurance elections and equity across offices regarding perpetuation funds.
-

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - The auditor's staff and financial team will compile all proposed departmental givebacks, salary adjustments, and revenue updates (including an added \$75,000 city election reimbursement line) into a revised summary report.
 - The next work session meeting was scheduled for **September 22nd** (immediately following the afternoon county commissioners' meeting).
- **Adjournment:** The meeting stood in recess until the conclusion of the September 22nd council meeting [Approved by Voice Vote].

Muncie Policy Memo Civic Monitoring Automated Pipeline. Report generated on 2026-09-12 11:35:17 using model gemini-3.5-flash-lite.